

**UNITED STATES OF AMERICA
BEFORE THE
FEDERAL ENERGY REGULATORY COMMISSION**

**Interconnection of Large Loads to the Interstate
Transmission System**

Docket No. RM26-4-000

COMMENTS OF ALLIANT ENERGY CORPORATE SERVICES, INC.

Alliant Energy Corporate Services, Inc. (“Alliant Energy”) respectfully submits the following comments in response to the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission’s (the “Commission”) Advanced Notice of Proposed Rulemaking (“ANOPR”)¹ issued on October 27, 2025, in the above-captioned docket. The ANOPR seeks comments on fourteen principles designed to govern the interconnection of large loads to the interstate transmission system, including study procedures, cost allocation, hybrid facilities, and reliability requirements.²

I. Alliant Energy

Alliant Energy Corporate Services, Inc. is a service company affiliate of Interstate Power and Light Company (“IPL”) and Wisconsin Power and Light Company (“WPL” collectively, the “Alliant Energy Operating Companies”). IPL is a load-serving entity that owns and operates electric facilities engaged in the generation, purchase, distribution, and sale of electric power and energy in Iowa. WPL is a load-serving entity that owns and operates electric facilities engaged in the generation, purchase, distribution and sale of electric power and energy in Wisconsin. Neither of the Alliant Energy Operating Companies owns or operates transmission facilities and have divested their transmission assets to independent transmission companies. The Alliant Energy Operating Companies are market participants in Midcontinent Independent System

¹ *Notice Inviting Comments, Interconnection of Large Loads to the Interstate Transmission System*, Docket. No. RM26-4-000 (Oct. 27, 2025).

² ANOPR at PP 17-31.

Operator Inc. (“MISO”) and incur costs associated with the purchase of transmission, capacity, energy, and ancillary market services within the MISO market.

II. Executive Summary

Alliant Energy understands the Commission’s desire to improve the efficiency, processes, and timelines for the interconnection of large loads while ensuring that all customers are treated equitably and that the costs of interconnection are allocated fairly. The Alliant Energy Operating Companies are effectively coordinating with our respective transmission owners, American Transmission Company, LLC (“ATC”) for WPL in Wisconsin and ITC Midwest LLC (“ITC Midwest”) for IPL in Iowa, and MISO to interconnect four large loads totaling approximately 3 GW of load³ within our service territories. As the Commission considers setting rules for large load interconnection in response to the ANOPR, the Commission should ensure that its efforts do not create uncertainty or conflicts between state and federal rules or cause delays for existing large load interconnections that are moving forward in a timely manner. Further, given the stated goal of the ANOPR to accelerate the interconnection of large loads to the transmission system, Alliant Energy encourages the Commission to design rules that, as much as possible, support straightforward and rapid compliance processes and implementation by transmission providers.

The Alliant Energy Operating Companies are presently utilizing existing load interconnection processes in the MISO region to study, contract, and integrate new large loads while continuing to serve a diverse customer base that includes residential, commercial, and industrial customers. Their respective service territories are currently experiencing load growth,

³ Alliant Energy Q3 Earnings Call Presentation, Slide 9
https://s201.q4cdn.com/991130938/files/doc_financials/2025/q3/Alliant-Energy_LNT-Q3-2025-Earnings-Slides_final_revised.pdf.

including growing interest from large load customers. These large load customers bring significant economic development to the communities Alliant Energy serves. For example, one customer locating in our Iowa service territory has announced plans to invest \$10 billion in the Cedar Rapids area, which represents not only the largest economic development investment in Cedar Rapids history, but also for the State of Iowa.⁴ This project represents a long-term commitment to innovation, infrastructure, and regional growth. Cumulatively, the customer's project is expected to support over 2,000 high-quality construction and permanent jobs that will benefit both the local community and the state. Load growth, whether that is in the form of agricultural, technological, or manufacturing customers, creates an opportunity to maintain affordable rates for all customers as that growth helps to spread out fixed costs, support load predictability, and increase efficiency of grid assets. Thus, ensuring the efficient interconnection of large load customers is both timely and essential.

It is also essential that the interconnection of existing large loads that are already advancing on schedule continue moving forward. Therefore, the Commission should focus on well-designed rules to safeguard customer interests, ensure reliability, appropriate cost allocation, and equitable treatment. Establishing clear, transparent, and fair rules will enable straightforward compliance and reduce administrative burdens, fostering a more efficient regulatory environment. For the Alliant Energy Operating Companies, timely interconnection supports economic development and ensures that customers can access the energy they need without undue delay. Moreover, rules that incorporate robust safeguards will enable all customers to share in the benefits of system contributions from new large load customers and

⁴ See QTS Announces New, World-Class Data Center Campus in Cedar Rapids, press release issued August 8, 2025, available at: <https://qtsdatacenters.com/news/qts-announces-new-world-class-datacenter-campus-in-cedar-rapids/>.

strengthen the entire energy system while promoting innovation and flexibility in meeting future load requirements.

The Commission must ensure that any changes adopted are paired with practical measures to mitigate risks of delay and uncertainty. Further, any Commission rules must continue to recognize the important role of state regulatory commissions in determining the rates of retail customers, including large load customers served by the Alliant Energy Operating Companies pursuant to carefully negotiated agreements.

The following comments address, among other things, principles outlined in the ANOPR and offer considerations to strengthen the Commission's proposed rulemaking, final rule, and implementation. These recommendations aim to ensure reforms deliver on their promise of reliability, fairness, and timely integration of large loads. They include increasing the minimum interconnection size to at least 100 MW, accounting for reliability and customer impacts when studying load and generation together, reducing speculative projects through deposits and readiness requirements, and expediting studies for curtailable loads while allowing flexibility in curtailment agreements.

III. Comments of Alliant Energy

A. The Minimum Interconnection Size for Large Loads Should be Increased to at Least 100 MW

The ANOPR proposes that any new rule apply to new gross or net loads greater than 20 MW consistent with the Commission's *pro forma* Large Generator Interconnection Procedures ("LGIP") and Large Generator Interconnection Agreement ("LGIA").⁵ Alliant Energy strongly recommends that the Commission increase the minimum applicability threshold from 20 MW to

⁵ ANOPR at P 19.

at least 100 MW. While aligning with the generator interconnection threshold has some appeal, the nature and scale of the loads driving this ANOPR, primarily hyperscale data centers, are fundamentally different from the smaller loads that would be captured by a 20 MW threshold. As such, the Commission should reconsider setting the threshold at 20 MW. Such a low threshold would unnecessarily draw numerous smaller, less impactful projects into the interconnection process, creating backlogs, congestion, and delays that undermine the very objectives of the ANOPR. By establishing a threshold of at least 100 MW, the Commission can ensure that interconnection resources are focused where they deliver the greatest system benefits.

In addition, a 100 MW threshold enables the Commission, transmission providers, and operators to focus limited study resources on the largest and most complex loads with the greatest system impact, while exempting smaller industrial and commercial customers from unnecessary requirements. This threshold reflects the scale of modern data centers and other large facilities driving these reforms and ensures that rules are tailored to their unique characteristics. By concentrating on projects where system contributions are most significant, the Commission can create an efficient, fair, and forward-looking interconnection framework that supports timely integration and effective load management across the grid.

B. The Study of Load and Generation Including Netting Should Account for Reliability, Affordability, and Customer Impacts

The ANOPR proposes that, to the extent practicable, load and hybrid facilities should be studied together with generating facilities.⁶ The Alliant Energy Operating Companies are transmission dependent utilities (“TDU”) that do not directly own or operate transmission assets, which provides a unique perspective on transmission development. While supporting necessary transmission build-out to maintain reliability and meet system needs remains a priority, TDUs

⁶ ANOPR at P 20.

approach these decisions without bias towards transmission solutions and with a commitment to minimizing costs where possible. Efficient siting of loads and generating facilities is essential, as the location of a large load near or at the same point of interconnection as a new generating facility can significantly reduce network upgrades. However, it is critical for the Commission to recognize that simply assuming generation and load offset each other is insufficient and could jeopardize reliability, affordability, and customer interests. Any study process the Commission implements should accurately account for the operational realities of combined load and generation at a single point of interconnection, ensuring reliability and cost-effectiveness for all customers.

Reliability Considerations

Generation and load interconnection studies serve different purposes. Generally speaking, generation interconnection studies address power injection to confirm that the point of interconnection and surrounding system can support new generation. In contrast, load interconnections focus on the ability to meet demand without destabilizing the grid and services for others. When generation and load are netted, distinct study requirements and operational characteristics must be addressed. For example, large AI data centers, with their size and variable demand, require careful analysis. Misalignment between load and generation capacity factors at a shared interconnection point can lead to injections or withdrawals from the Bulk Electric System (“BES”), requiring full review of interconnection and network upgrades, including transmission service when load exceeds generation at hybrid facilities. Study procedures and related agreements should incorporate relay and control schemes to limit net injections or withdrawals from the BES, ensuring reliability and system integrity.

No generation resource can deliver guaranteed, continuous output, so in hybrid configurations load and generation will not always align. A full system impact study and necessary upgrades are required to account for the generator's maximum injection when load is absent and to ensure the load is served when generation is unavailable. Coordinating in-service and commissioning timelines for both components adds complexity, making it essential to study scenarios where one becomes operational without the other. The Commission should require study processes and agreements to include clear operational controls and relay schemes that limit harmful net injections or withdrawals, thereby protecting reliability and maintaining system integrity.

Affordability and Customer Impacts

To protect customers from bearing costs caused by load at a hybrid facility using grid services when not self-generating, or when the anticipated load does not materialize, it is essential to determine the system upgrades required. This determination should be based on a study of the potential impacts if full load or maximum generation were to import from or export to the grid. Without such analysis and corresponding network upgrades, risks related to energy market costs, congestion management, and resource adequacy could be unfairly shifted to other customers.

The Commission should adopt policies that require robust study protocols and clear modeling standards when evaluating combined load and generation at a single interconnection point. These measures will help maintain reliability, protect affordability, and enable efficient siting without unintended consequences. By addressing these risks proactively, the Commission can establish a framework that supports innovation while safeguarding system integrity and preserving progress already made.

Netting Proposal

Alliant Energy cautions against the netting proposal in the ANOPR. Netting assumes that load and generation at the same point of interconnection can offset one another for transmission planning purposes, but this oversimplification ignores critical operational realities. Load and generation do not behave in a perfectly correlated manner—generation can be intermittent or unavailable, while load remains firm and must be served at all times. Treating these resources as interchangeable risks underestimating system needs, which could compromise reliability and increase costs for all customers.

The netting proposal places independent system operators (“ISOs”) and regional transmission operators (“RTOs”) in the untenable position of evaluating retail access rules governed by state-level policies, an area clearly outside their jurisdiction. Rather than relying on flawed assumptions, the most effective way to meet growing demand from large loads like data centers is to accelerate the generation interconnection process. MISO’s Expedited Resource Addition Study (“ERAS”) process illustrates how this can work in practice.⁷ ERAS prioritizes a limited number of critical resource interconnections and studies them on an expedited timeline, enabling projects to advance quickly while ensuring both load and generation are accurately represented in planning models.

The Alliant Energy Operating Companies currently have seven projects in the ERAS process, including two in the first study cycle. Our experience shows that ERAS delivers exactly what is needed: timely studies that allow development activity to proceed and ensure system reliability. Expedited interconnection processes like ERAS—not netting—are the right solution to integrate large loads efficiently and maintain a robust, reliable grid.

⁷ See MISO, FERC Electric Tariff, attach. X (Generator Interconnection Procedures (GIP)) (182.0.0), § 3.9 (Expedited Resource Addition Study).

C. Use of Study Deposits and Readiness Requirements to Prevent Speculative Projects from Causing Delays in the Interconnection of Large Loads

The ANOPR proposes applying standardized study deposits, readiness requirements, and withdrawals penalties to large loads, similar to those for generating facilities, and seeks comments on whether existing requirements should be adopted.⁸ Alliant Energy supports policies that encourage readiness for large load interconnections, including reasonable measures such as study deposits and readiness requirements, to prevent speculative projects from creating delays or backlogs. These requirements, however, should be tailored to the unique characteristics of large loads rather than simply mirroring generator policies, ensuring that the process remains focused on projects prepared to advance.

Study Deposits

Alliant Energy supports implementing study deposits requirements for large load interconnection studies, as no such framework currently exists in MISO. To assist the Commission in developing this framework, the study deposit structure established under Order No. 2023⁹ for generator interconnections can serve as a useful guide. While this framework provides a strong starting point, flexibility should be granted to transmission providers, and ISOs/RTOs to determine the appropriate study deposit size for large loads. Applying a study deposit requirement can help ensure that only viable, commercially ready projects enter the study process, identify non-viable projects earlier, and shorten timelines, benefiting existing and future large load customers. Upfront deposits can also provide greater certainty for interconnection

⁸ ANOPR at P 21.

⁹ *Improvements to Generator Interconnection Procs. & Agreements*, Order No. 2023, 184 FERC ¶ 61,054, *order on reh'g*, 185 FERC ¶ 61,063 (2023), *order on reh'g*, Order No. 2023-A, 186 FERC ¶ 61,199, *errata notice*, 188 FERC ¶ 61,134 (2024).

customers and transmission providers, enabling more accurate load forecasting and system planning, which improves reliability and overall efficiency.

Readiness Requirements

Similarly, the Commission should leverage existing commercial readiness requirements for generator interconnection as a model for large load interconnection customers to demonstrate commercial viability, secured permits, and financing. However, a one-size-fits-all approach would be counterproductive. Large load interconnection processes vary across transmission providers, and imposing uniform requirements risks disrupting effective practices already in place. Where readiness frameworks exist, the Commission should grant transmission providers broad latitude to maintain or minimally adjust those processes in the final rule. Flexibility is essential to avoid delays and preserve constructive progress toward timely large load interconnections.

MISO's Expedited Project Review ("EPR") process illustrates this principle.¹⁰ The EPR provides a fast-track path, outside the normal MISO Transmission Expansion Plan cycle, for transmission owners to address urgent reliability or load issues. With streamlined review and approval, projects can advance independently of the planning cycle and be completed in as little as two months. Enhancing this process with readiness requirements would ensure that large loads prepared to interconnect are prioritized over speculative projects, reinforcing the ANOPR's goals without undermining proven mechanisms that already facilitate timely interconnections.

¹⁰ MISO Business Practice Manual 20 Section 4.1.4, <https://cdn.misoenergy.org/BPM-020%20Transmission%20Planning113822.zip?v=20250124144741>.

D. Hybrid Facilities Issues for Large Load Interconnection Studies and Transmission Service Cost Allocation

The ANOPR proposes that hybrid facilities be studied based on their net injection or withdrawal rights, that transmission service be based on withdrawal rights, and that ancillary services be based on peak demand without consideration of co-located generation. While these concepts aim to address hybrid configurations, they raise critical reliability and cost allocation concerns that must be resolved in the final rule.

First, when load and generation share the same point of interconnection, operational safeguards are essential to maintain grid reliability and prevent unintended impacts on system operations. Key requirements include bidirectional flow control to block unintended injections or withdrawals, separate metering, and protection settings that isolate faults without affecting the transmission system. Compliance with NERC planning criteria should be non-negotiable, and additional criteria should be established by the relevant ISO/RTO and transmission owner. Proper studies and identification of necessary network upgrades are fundamental to ensuring reliability and fairness, and hybrid loads must pay for the benefits provided by the BES.

Second, the ANOPR also proposes inconsistent cost allocation—netting for transmission service while applying gross peak demand for ancillary services. This approach lacks justification and creates unnecessary complexity. Both transmission and ancillary services reflect the load’s reliance on the grid; therefore, the Commission should adopt a gross load approach for both, allowing exceptions only if supported by the utility and approved by the state regulator. This method aligns with Commission precedent under the MISO Open Access Transmission Tariff (“OATT”), which follows the Order No. 888,¹¹ *pro forma* OATT, the entire

¹¹ *Promoting Wholesale Competition Through Open Access Non-Discriminatory Transmission Servs. by Pub. Utils.; Recovery of Stranded Costs by Pub. Utils. & Transmitting Utils.*, Order No. 888, FERC Stats. & Regs. ¶ 31,036

load at a point of delivery should be designed at Network Load, including load served by behind-the-meter generation. Load at hybrid facilities should be treated like any other load to ensure proper study, charges, and operational planning by transmission providers.

Ancillary services are critical to maintain system reliability by supporting frequency regulation, voltage control, and reserves. These services must be procured to meet the full potential demand of a facility, regardless of whether generation at a hybrid facility offsets some energy needs during normal operations. During emergencies or contingencies, such as generator outages or transmission constraints, the system must serve the entire load. Therefore, planning and procurement of ancillary services must reflect the maximum possible demand, not a netted value that assumes generation will always be available. Alliant Energy cautions that netting for ancillary services would understate system obligations, leading to insufficient reserves, jeopardizing reliability, and increasing costs for other customers.

Finally, utilities serving large loads at hybrid facilities must comply with all applicable NERC reliability standards and OATT provisions. These requirements ensure the safe and reliable operation of the bulk electric system, support operational transparency, and prevent reliability gaps. Failure to enforce these standards could compromise system stability, voltage support, and contingency planning while increasing costs for customers. The Commission should adopt a gross load approach for both transmission and ancillary services, require operational safeguards for hybrid facilities, and mandate full compliance with NERC and OATT

(1996) (cross-referenced at 75 FERC ¶ 61,080), *order on reh'g*, Order No. 888-A, FERC Stats. & Regs. ¶ 31,048 (cross-referenced at 78 FERC ¶ 61,220), *order on reh'g*, Order No. 888-B, 81 FERC ¶ 61,248 (1997), *order on reh'g*, Order No. 888-C, 82 FERC ¶ 61,046 (1998), *aff'd in relevant part sub nom. Transmission Access Pol'y Study Grp. v. FERC*, 225 F.3d 667 (D.C. Cir. 2000), *aff'd sub nom. N.Y. v. FERC*, 535 U.S. 1. Order No. 888-A reinforced this principle: "*The bottom line is that all potential transmission customers, including those with generation behind the meter, must choose between network integration transmission service or point-to-point transmission service.*" Order No. 888-A, FERC Stats. & Regs. ¶ 31,048, at 30,260 (1997).

standards. These measures will ensure reliability, fairness, and consistency while supporting the ANOPR's objectives without introducing unnecessary risk or cost shifts.

E. Curtailable Large Loads Should Receive Expedited Study Treatment and Flexibility in Curtailment Agreements

The ANOPR's proposal to expedite interconnection studies for large loads that agree to curtailment is a sound principle, as curtailable loads can enhance system reliability and affordability. However, curtailable large loads should not be required to participate in a mandatory formal demand response program as it would unnecessarily hinder and discourage innovative solutions. Large loads, particularly data centers, often have unique operational characteristics and contractual arrangements that do not align with standardized demand response frameworks. Alliant Energy recommends that the Commission allow for flexible, bilateral agreements between large load customers and transmission providers. Such agreements can define key curtailment terms, including amount, notice period, and duration, tailored to the customer's capabilities and grid needs. This approach promotes collaboration, accelerates readiness, and avoids imposing rigid program requirements that could create barriers to participation. Alliant Energy recommends that the final rule clarify that eligibility for expedited study treatment can be based on these agreements, ensuring flexibility while advancing system-wide benefits.

F. Study Considerations for the Use of Existing Generation to Serve New Load

The ANOPR proposes requiring an existing generating facility seeking partial suspension to serve a new co-located load to undergo a system support resource ("SSR") or reliability must run ("RMR") -type study.¹² Alliant Energy supports a SSR or RMR-type study because it ensures potential reliability impacts and cost shifts are evaluated. A study process provides the

¹² ANOPR at P 27.

analysis needed to confirm whether the generation and load at the same point of interconnection can proceed without compromising system stability or imposing additional costs. Flexibility in implementation is equally important. Transmission providers should be able to use existing tariff-based procedures where appropriate, reducing administrative burden and accelerating timelines without sacrificing study integrity. This approach avoids unnecessary delays and costs while meeting the Commission’s reliability objectives.

G. Transition Rules for Implementing a New Large Load Interconnection Process

The Commission should establish a clear transition point for implementing new processes under this rule. At a minimum, large loads that have begun the formal interconnection process with the relevant transmission owner or provider by the rule’s effective date should continue without having to backtrack to meet new requirements. Secretary Wright’s stated goal is to ensure large loads can “connect to the transmission system in a timely, orderly, and non-discriminatory manner.”¹³ Alliant Energy Operating Companies have continued to achieve these goals in collaboration with ITC Midwest and ATC under current MISO rules. Changing course at this stage would cause significant delays, drive up costs, and create uncertainty for projects already underway. Large load interconnections often involve substantial planning, engineering, and contractual commitments. Forcing these projects to restart under new rules could disrupt timelines, jeopardize customer commitments, and undermine confidence in the interconnection process. However, maintaining continuity ensures that investments made under existing procedures are preserved, while still allowing new reforms to apply prospectively without penalizing projects that have acted in good faith under current rules.

¹³ Secretary of Energy’s Direction that the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission Initiate Rulemaking Procedures and Proposal Regarding the Interconnection of Large Loads Pursuant to the Secretary’s Authority Under Section 403 of the Department of Energy Organization Act (Oct. 23, 2025).

Although the ANOPR sets an accelerated timeline to finalize the rule by April 30, 2026, implementation will take time. After the rule becomes effective, transmission providers must collaborate with stakeholders on compliance filings, followed by additional steps for full implementation. Whatever transition mechanism the Commission adopts, it should ensure that ongoing interconnection projects are not delayed or disrupted.

H. Additional Considerations for the Large Load Interconnection Rulemaking

Many states and load serving entities have already taken and continue to take significant steps to address the interconnection of large loads, and the Commission's eventual final rule should not derail or counteract this progress. To accomplish this, the Commission should continue its long-standing precedent, most recently reiterated in Order No. 2023,¹⁴ to evaluate obligations that result from any final rule in this proceeding under the independent entity variation standard for ISOs/RTOs and the consistent with or superior to standard for non-ISO/RTO transmission providers. Adopting these standards will facilitate a much more streamlined compliance and implementation process while hopefully avoiding overly prescriptive directives on this rapidly evolving issue.

In the ANOPR, large loads that share a point of interconnection with new or existing generation facilities are termed "hybrid facilities."¹⁵ The Commission should avoid using this term in the final rule, as it may create confusion with existing hybrid definitions in tariffs and other contexts. Additionally, generation and load sharing an interconnection point can involve varied contractual arrangements, which could lead to inconsistent outcomes under a standardized process or conflict with state regulatory frameworks. Instead, the Commission should describe

¹⁴ Order No. 2023 at PP 10, 1764.

¹⁵ ANOPR at P 12.

interconnection options at a high level and allow flexibility for innovative policies as load-serving entities gain experience with large load interconnections.

Finally, compliance and implementation of any final rule will be a significant undertaking for transmission providers, load-serving entities, large load customers, and other stakeholders. The electric industry is already balancing multiple critical priorities, including reliability and resource adequacy. To ensure the benefits of any final rule are realized, the Commission should emphasize the need for transmission providers to reprioritize efforts toward timely compliance, even if this requires adjusting or deferring other initiatives.

IV. Conclusion

Alliant Energy appreciates the opportunity to provide perspective and recommendations on the important issues raised in the ANOPR. By pairing measures that promote efficient large load interconnection development with safeguards to protect customers and load-serving entities from excessive rates and adverse impacts, the Commission can achieve its goal of improving large load interconnection while addressing reliability and cost allocation concerns.

Respectfully submitted,

/s/ Jay Sher

Jay Sher

Lead Federal Regulatory Relations Manager

Alliant Energy Corporate Services

801 Pennsylvania Avenue, Suite 330

Washington, DC 20004

Tel.: (240) 701-0721

Email: jaysher@alliantenergy.com